

Envelope 12 • Shawwal • The Years Nobody Was Watching

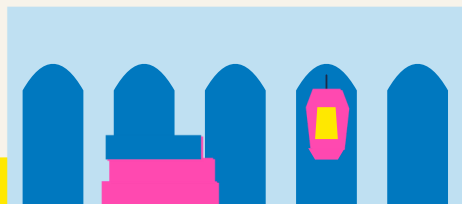
Style E — Riso Press. Space Grotesk and Atkinson Hyperlegible. Every word read from source; every drawing from tools/envelope_art.py, which has no figure in it.

Still open where it shows: the fact panel is TO VERIFY and the return address is not set.

ENVELOPE — C5, 229 × 162 MM

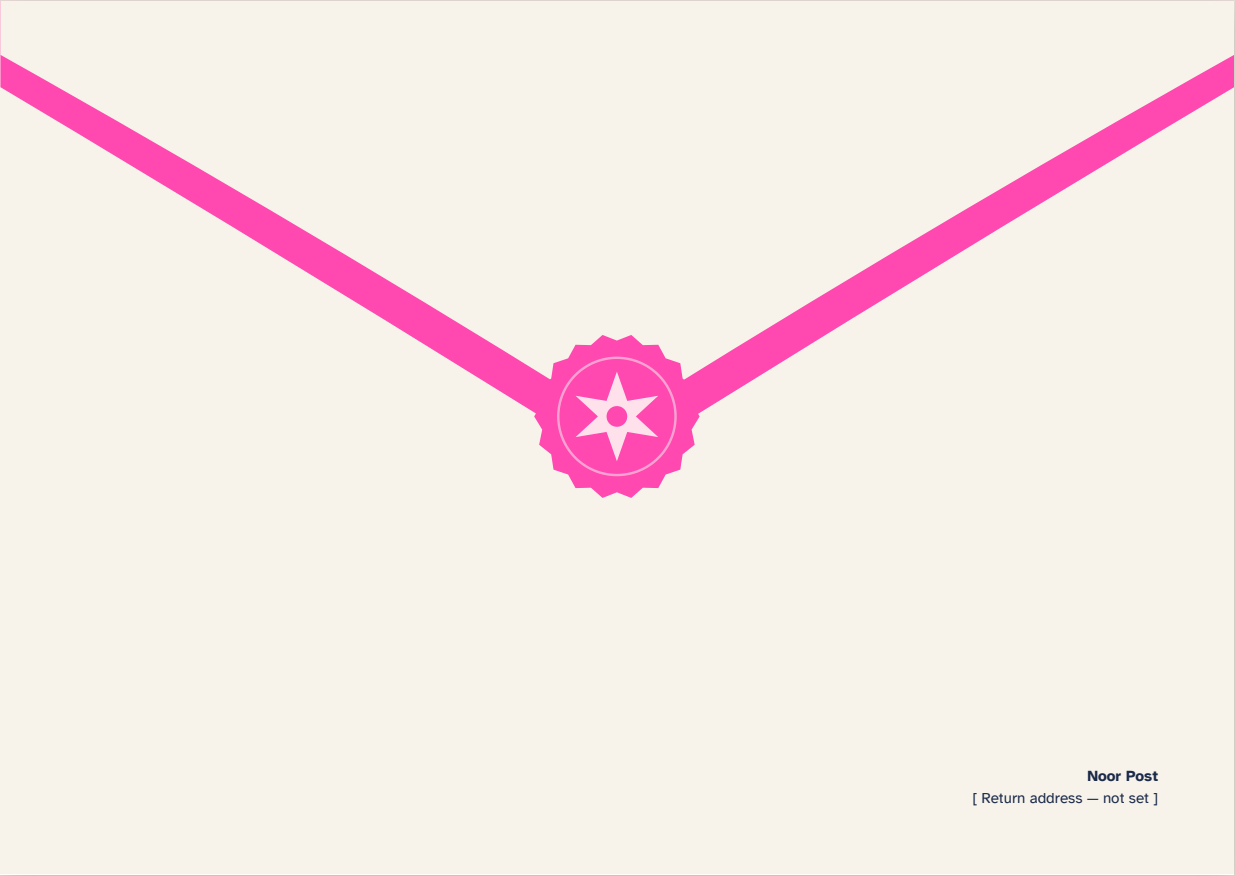
NOOR POST

One of fourteen. Open it on the day.



FOR

[Child's name]



Noor Post

[Return address — not set]

INSIDE THE FLAP

ENVELOPE 12 • SHAWWAL •
INSIDE THE FLAP

Open together.

🕒 **About twenty-five minutes**

● is the grown-up. ○ is you.

- 1 The letter — read it out loud, ● and ○ taking turns
- 2 The hadith card
- 3 The prints
- 4 Talk about it
- 5 The stickers
- 6 The postcard



THE LETTER — ONE A4 SHEET FOLDED TO A5

Imam Ja'far al-Sadiq

(peace be upon him)

B. 83 AH, MEDINA • D. 148 AH, MEDINA

- **Where and when.** Medina, almost entirely. He did not need to travel; for once, people were allowed to come to him.
- **Who was ruling.** First the Umayyads from Damascus, then — after a war that changed the empire — the Abbasids from Iraq. He lived through the whole changeover. **The gap between the two is his working life.**
- **The imamate.** About thirty-four years, from 114 AH, from the age of about thirty-one.
- **What he left.** Named students, in lists that survive. Zurara, Muhammad ibn Muslim, Hisham ibn al-Hakam and many more. Others who sat in that circle went on to be founders of schools of law of their own. And Jabir ibn Hayyan, who worked on substances and their reactions, and is claimed as an ancestor by chemistry.
- **Umm Farwa.** His mother. She was the daughter of a well-known scholar of Medina and grew up in a household of them — he did not learn only from his father's side, and the accounts say so plainly.
- **Elsewhere in the world.** In the same years, China was putting itself back together after a rebellion that had emptied whole provinces and nearly ended the dynasty — one empire coming apart while another was being replaced.

He died in Medina in 148 AH. Shia accounts hold that he was killed on the orders of the caliph al-Mansur.

The Years Nobody Was Watching



• is the grown-up • ○ is you • ● is together

• For most of this box, somebody is being watched. A house is under guard, a road is closed, a man is being followed to the market. This envelope is about the one stretch when that stopped, and what got done in it.

○ Why did it stop?

• Because the government was busy falling over. One family had ruled that empire for about ninety years, and another family was taking it off them, and for a while everybody in charge was looking at each other rather than at Medina.

○ How long is a while?

• Long enough. Years, not months.

• Now — if nobody is watching you, and you have wanted room your whole life, what do you do with it? You could raise an army. Plenty of people told him to.

○ Did he?

• No. He did not take one step toward it. He opened a class instead.

THE YEARS NOBODY WAS WATCHING • CONTINUED

- A circle in a courtyard in Medina, most days, going on for years. Anybody could come. And they came from everywhere, and the important part is this: we know their names. Not a crowd, not a number somebody made up afterwards. Lists of people, one by one, who sat there.

○ Who?

- Men who went on to run schools of law of their own, and are still argued about today by people who have no idea where they studied. Men who wrote the books that other books quote.

- And one man who spent his life on furnaces and glass and what happens when you mix one thing with another. Jabir ibn Hayyan. What he was doing did not have a name yet. It does now. We call it chemistry.

○ What would you do with a year nobody was watching? Say it now.

- He had the one thing none of his fathers had and none of his sons would get. Room. And he did not spend it on a throne or an army or getting even.

- He spent it on people who would still be teaching after he was dead.

SAY THIS ONE TOGETHER

●○

He had room. He filled it.



Then the hadith card.

IMAM AL-SADIQ SAID

**“He who treats people kindly
will be accepted as arbiter.”**

Imam al-Sadiq

NOOR POST · THE FOURTEEN

The chain

Every card in this box is one link. Lay all fourteen in order and the chain runs from the Prophet to the last of the twelve, each one passing on what was given.



Fourteen segments · historical order

IN OUR WORDS

**Be kind to people, and they will trust you
to settle their arguments.**

Noor Post's own words, not the translation.

Tuhaf al-Uqul, short maxims, no. 1. Translated by Badr Shahin, Ansariyan Publications, Qum.



SESSION CARD

Talk about it

About ten minutes. No right answers, and no points.

- 1 People told him to raise an army and he opened a class instead. Which one lasts longer?
- 2 • Grown-up answers this one first.
Name a teacher you had whose name you still remember, and say what you got from them.
- 3 His students disagreed with each other, sometimes badly, and he taught them anyway. Should he have?

TURN OVER →



TALK ABOUT IT • CONTINUED

4

One of them spent his life on what happens when you mix things. Nobody had a word for it yet. What are people doing now that has no word for it yet?

5

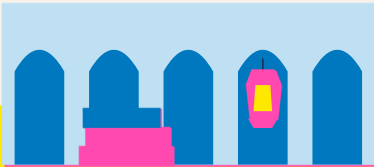
■ This one is hard for a grown-up.

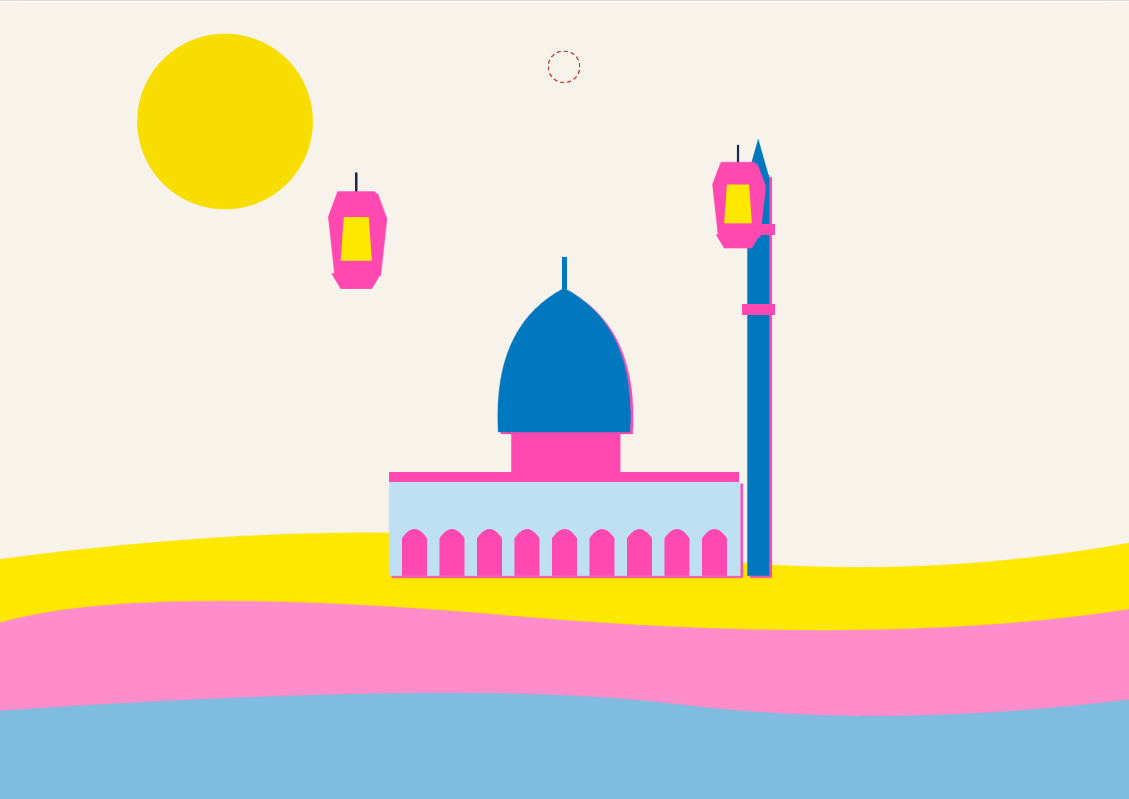
He got about ten free years and used them on something that paid nothing back in his lifetime. What are you doing with yours?

LAST

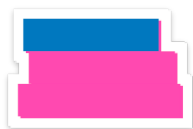
Teach each other something. Five minutes each. ● goes second.



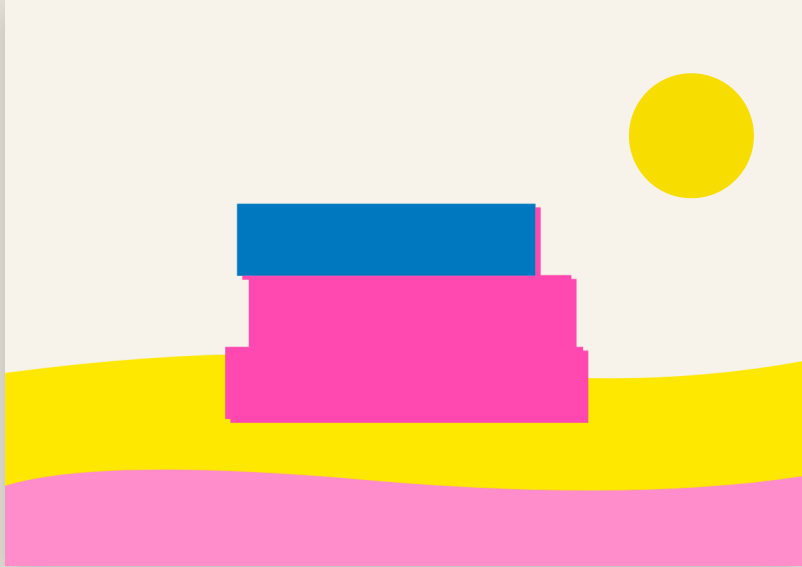




STICKER SHEET — A6, KISS-CUT



RETURN POSTCARD — A6 LANDSCAPE



We opened this one
together.

● _____

○ _____

Post it back to us, or keep it. Either is right.

Noor Post

[Return address — not set]



